

Checklist

Tech Lead Checklist

Role and mindset

- ☐ I understand that my job is not just to write code, but to help the team deliver.
- ☐ I balance technical work with leadership, communication, and project planning.
- ☐ I focus on team outcomes, not just my own individual output.
- ☐ I am willing to influence without formal authority.
- ☐ I know when to step in directly and when to delegate.

Technical leadership

- ☐ I understand the architecture well enough to confidently lead changes.
- ☐ I know the project's critical systems, dependencies, and risks.
- ☐ I identify which technical decisions I should make, delegate, or escalate.
- ☐ I gather input from the team before making major technical decisions.
- ☐ I avoid becoming either a bottleneck or totally hands-off.

Planning and execution

- ☐ I can break large projects into smaller deliverables and tasks.
- ☐ I can identify what can happen in parallel versus what must happen in sequence.
- ☐ I know which items are critical and which are optional.
- ☐ I keep the project moving, not just the codebase evolving.
- ☐ I revisit the plan as new information appears.

Project management

- ☐ I create enough structure for estimates, sequencing, and prioritization.
- ☐ I push through ambiguity rather than avoid planning work.
- ☐ I communicate project status, risks, and tradeoffs early.
- ☐ I use planning to reduce uncertainty, not to pretend uncertainty does not exist.
- ☐ I prepare for delivery with a premortem, launch plan, and rollback plan.

Team leadership

- I help teammates unblock themselves instead of hoarding the most interesting work.
- I delegate work in ways that help the team grow.
- I provide mentorship and guidance, even when I am not their manager.
- I help the team focus on what matters most.
- I avoid heroics that hide problems rather than solve them.

Communication

- I represent the team clearly to management and partner teams.
- I explain technical issues in language others can understand.
- I listen carefully and repeat back key points to confirm understanding.
- I write clearly, speak clearly, and communicate often.
- I raise concerns early instead of waiting for a crisis.

Team effectiveness

- ☐ I protect the team's focus time from unnecessary meetings and interruptions.
- ☐ I help stakeholders respect the team's need for deep work.
- ☐ I make sure meeting load does not overwhelm individual contributors.
- ☐ I remove obstacles that slow the team down.
- ☐ I prioritize sustainable productivity over constant urgency.

Process and judgment

- ☐ I use process as a tool, not as a substitute for leadership.
- ☐ I do not assume there is one perfect process that fixes everything.
- ☐ I optimize for people and interactions, not just rules and tools.
- ☐ I adapt the process to the team and the work.
- ☐ I look for self-regulating systems instead of policing people.

Personal growth

- ☐ I accept that being a tech lead requires learning new skills beyond coding.
- ☐ I am building skills in planning, prioritization, and coordination.
- ☐ I am getting better at handling ambiguity and responsibility.
- ☐ I regularly ask the team what they need from me most right now.
- ☐ I assess honestly whether I want to stay on the technical track, grow as a tech lead, or move into management.

Reflection questions

- ☐ Do I know what my manager expects from a tech lead?
- ☐ Do I know what my team expects from a tech lead?
- ☐ Am I spending too much time coding, or not enough?
- ☐ Am I making the team more effective, or just staying busy?
- ☐ Am I leading in a way that others trust and want to follow?